03 – Model selection & free plans

AI Training for Beginners

Self-study training: use AI/LLMs safely in everyday life

Version 1.0 • As of: October 2026

File: `03_model_selection.md`

https://github.com/mgunthner/AI-Training

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03 – Model selection & free plans

Definition: A **model** is the “engine” behind the chat, the program that processes your request. There are larger and smaller models with different quality, speed and costs. A **plan** is your tariff with the provider (e.g. free or subscription).

> **Remember:** For a shopping list you don’t need a truck, and for moving house you don’t need a bicycle.

Key points

- **Large vs. small:** Larger models are usually more thorough on tricky tasks, but slower, and they use up more of your limit. Smaller models are faster and good enough for routine tasks.
- **Standard vs. reasoning:** Reasoning models “think” internally before they answer. That helps with logic, planning and multi-step problems. More on this in topic 10.
- **Multimodal:** Some models process not only text but also images, audio and documents. Not every model can do everything.
- **Free plans often restrict:** access to certain models, usage volume, features (e.g. file upload, web search) and data use. The exact details change frequently.
- **Rule of thumb:** Simple task → small model. Tricky or important → larger model.
- **Bigger does not mean error-free:** Large models make things up too (topic 08).
- **Names and limits become outdated quickly:** check the current figures with your provider.

Example

Task 1: You want the subject line of an email phrased in a friendlier way. → A small, fast model is enough.

Task 2: You are comparing two mobile plans and want to weigh up pros and cons. → Better use a larger model, and check the result yourself.

```
I have to choose between two mobile plans. Plan A: shorter contract
↪  term,
higher price. Plan B: longer term, cheaper price.
I mainly use my phone for messaging and navigation.
```

```
Compare both plans in a table and name the questions
I should clarify before signing up.
```

Do / Don’t

Do	Don’t
Choose the model to fit the task	Always take the largest model
Cross-check important results	Blindly trust a large model
Try a smaller model when you hit limits	Use reasoning mode for translating or rephrasing

Safety note

On the free plan, inputs can be stored and, depending on provider or settings, used for training – no matter which model you choose. Check your privacy settings (topic 04).

Mini checklist

- ☐ I know the difference between large and small models.
- ☐ I know when I need a larger model or reasoning mode.
- ☐ I know what my free plan restricts and have checked that with the provider.
- ☐ I check important results, no matter which model produced them.

Exercise (5 min.)

Solve the same task with two models, modes (standard and reasoning mode) or services.

```
Plan three days in a city of your choice for two people on a small
↪ budget. Give a plan for each day plus a rainy-day alternative.
```

Compare: quality, speed, comprehensibility. Note your conclusion in your prompt library.

Next

- Extra exercises: `02_extra_exercises/03_extra_exercises`
- Test: Test A (Foundation)
- Related: 01 What is AI?, 04 Data privacy, 10 Reasoning effort, 15 Cost control

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